

HIS592 World Church History I — Syllabus

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Asia Pacific Theological Seminary Instructor: Dr. Ang Li Credits: 3 | Location: ARC Room 301 Dates: June 20 – July 7, 2026

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course introduces the history of the Christian church from the post-apostolic period to the dawn of the Reformation era. The main emphasis is to acquaint students with major historical developments, key figures, movements, and doctrines of that time, while asking how this history shapes ministry and scholarship today.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

Upon completion of this course, the student should be able to:

- Discuss the overall history of the world Christian movement through the 15th century, including diverse movements and traditions
 - Recognize primary contributors to Christian thought and mission during this period
 - Understand major theological controversies and how culture and ecclesial tensions influenced their development
 - Understand the rise and spread of Islam and its impact on Christianity in the Mediterranean, Africa, and Asia
 - Identify what effect historical and theological developments of this period have had on the church today
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REQUIRED TEXT

González, Justo L. *The Story of Christianity, Volume 1: The Early Church to the Dawn of the Reformation*. Revised and updated ed. HarperOne, 2010.

Supplemental (for country-history presentations when González is thin):

- Moffett, Samuel H. *A History of Christianity in Asia, Vol. 1*. HarperSanFrancisco, 1992.
 - Jenkins, Philip. *The Lost History of Christianity*. HarperOne, 2008.
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AI POLICY

AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, etc.) are permitted for brainstorming, source discovery, translation, outlining, and drafting. AI is not a substitute for source verification, oral presentation, or personal ministry reflection. Every major assignment must include a brief **AI Use Report** (one paragraph): what tool was used, how, and what was verified manually.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS & GRADING

Assignment	%
Attendance and class participation	20%
González reading group presentation	15%
Home country / region group presentation	25%
Final project track	40%

Attendance and Participation (20%): Attend all sessions. Be punctual. Engage in discussions and at least one scripted class interaction (role-play, primary source, or debate) as assigned each term.

González Reading Group Presentation (15%): Each of the 8 groups is assigned one reading block from González by page range so the workload is more even across the class. Each group gives a 15–20 minute presentation at the start of the relevant session. Cover: key figures, main developments, one discussion question for the class. A one-page handout or slide set is required. AI may assist with preparation; students handle live Q&A. This replaces weekly reading papers and distributes the survey across the class.

Home Country / Region Group Presentation (25%): Groups present a 15-minute class presentation on the history of Christianity in their home country or region using the Three Lenses format (see below). A brief check-in with the instructor is required by Session 6. Students from the Philippines or any country with large numbers may form two sub-groups by region, island cluster, or denomination.

Final Project (40%): Students choose one track at the start of the course.

FINAL PROJECT TRACKS

Ministry Video Reflection — Video (5 min) + 1-page ministry memo + AI Use Report

Create a video (1) detailing 1–2 takeaways; (2) how you would apply parts of the course to your current or future ministry. The memo is for your own reflection.

Historical Figure Project — Profile of one historical figure + ministry reflection + AI Use Report

Students who want to focus on a person may choose one historical figure from any period of church history, including the Puritan or missionary era. Present: (1) who they were — their theology, ministry, congregation, family, and failures; (2) what their life and ministry taught you about your own life or ministry; (3) at least 1–2 changes in perspective or things you will do differently as a result. Format may be approved by the instructor as a recorded presentation, live presentation, or short written profile.

GONZÁLEZ READING GROUP PRESENTATIONS

The class is divided into 8 groups. Each group is assigned one reading block of roughly comparable length by page range and chapter span. This is the primary mode of covering the textbook — presentations replace reading papers.

Group	Pages (González)	Chapter Block	Session	Content
1 Jardine	pp. 14–72	Ch. 1–6	1	Introduction, post-apostolic world,

Group	Pages (González)	Chapter Block	Session	Content
2 Ifrahim	pp. 74–125	Ch. 7–10	2	Jerusalem church, mission to the Gentiles, first persecutions Apologists, canon and creed, early teachers, third-century persecution Christian life, great persecution, Constantine, Eusebius and official theology
3 Vanessa	pp. 126–180	Ch. 11–14	3	Monasticism, Donatism, Arian controversy, Julian, Athanasius Cappadocians, Ambrose, Chrysostom, Jerome, Augustine, end of the ancient era
4 Lori	pp. 181–236	Ch. 15–19	4	New medieval order, Eastern Christianity, Charlemagne and imperial restoration Papal and monastic reform, Crusades, golden age of medieval Christianity
5 Joel	pp. 237–297	Ch. 20–26	5	Collapse, reform movements, Renaissance, humanism, threshold of Reformation
6 Ben	pp. 298–359	Ch. 27–29	6	
7 Agnes	pp. 360–424	Ch. 30–32	7 AM	
8 Joshua	pp. 425–494	Ch. 33–35	7 PM	

Presentation requirements: 15–20 minutes, one handout or slide set, minimum 2 sources beyond González, AI Use Report, 2 discussion questions for the class.

HOME COUNTRY / REGION PRESENTATION — THREE LENSES FORMAT

Every group structures their 15 minutes the same way:

- 1. **González or Selected Bibliography Narrative (4 min):** What does González/others say about your region, and what does he miss? Quote him directly.
- 2. **Primary Tradition or Figure (6 min):** Who or what carried Christianity in, and what did it cost? If your tradition has a hymn or chant or other interactive element with historical roots, use it.
- 3. **The Inheritance Question (5 min, incl. 2 min class response):** Pick a theme from González/Selected Bibliography and say how it arrived in your country and what your church did with it.

Session 1 task: Groups form and choose their country or region. Presentation angle and sources to be discussed with instructor by Session 6.

PLAGIARISM POLICY

APTS considers plagiarism a serious violation of Christian integrity and academic ethics. Plagiarism involves using material written by another without proper citation or representing material written by another as one’s own work, including undisclosed AI-generated content. Penalties can include failing the assignment, failing the course, or expulsion.

TENTATIVE CLASS SCHEDULE

Session	Date	Day	Time	Topic	González
1	June 22	Mon	8:00–12:00 PM	Course intro; post-apostolic world; Jerusalem church; mission to the Gentiles — Grp 1 presents	Ch. 1–6
2	June 22	Mon	1:00–5:00 PM	Apologists, canon, creed, early teachers, third-century persecution — Grp 2 presents	Ch. 7–10
3	June 29	Mon	8:00 AM–12:00 NN	Christian life, great persecution, Constantine, Eusebius — Grp 3 presents	Ch. 11–14

Session	Date	Day	Time	Topic	González
	June 30	Tue	6:00–9:00 PM	Continuation / make-up block	
4	July 1	Wed	1:30–5:20 PM	Monasticism, Donatism, Arian controversy, Julian, Athanasius — Grp 4 presents	Ch. 15–19
5	July 3	Fri	1:30–5:20 PM	Cappadocians, Ambrose, Chrysostom, Jerome, Augustine, end of the ancient era — Grp 5 presents	Ch. 20–26
6	July 4	Sat	8:00 AM–12:00 NN	New medieval order, Eastern Christianity, Charlemagne — Grp 6 presents; check-ins	Ch. 27–29
			1:00–5:20 PM	Papal reform, Crusades, high medieval Christianity — Primary Source Workshop	Ch. 30–32
7	July 6	Mon	8:00 AM–12:00 NN	Papal reform, Crusades, high medieval Christianity — Grp 7 presents	Ch. 30–32
			1:00–5:20 PM	Late medieval crisis, reform movements, Renaissance, country presentations, final track showcases — Grp 8 presents	Ch. 33–35

Final submissions due: July 8, 2026

SELECTED BIBLIOGRAPHY

- González, Justo L. *The Story of Christianity, Volume 1*. HarperOne, 2010.
- Jenkins, Philip. *The Lost History of Christianity*. HarperOne, 2008.
- Moffett, Samuel H. *A History of Christianity in Asia, Vol. 1*. HarperSanFrancisco, 1992.
- Irvin, Dale T. and Scott W. Sunquist. *History of the World Christian Movement, Vol. 1*. Orbis, 2001.
- Shelley, Bruce L. *Church History in Plain Language*. 4th ed. Thomas Nelson, 2013.
- Chua, Tony, comp. *History Reader for World Church History I*. 2022.